

The Washington Post

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SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Partly sunny, breezy 51/32 • Tomorrow: Snow, sleet 36/33 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 7, 2025 • \$4

Syria’s new rulers may let Russia keep bases

‘In politics, there are no permanent enemies,’ defense minister says

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS AND ZAKARIA ZAKARIA

DAMASCUS, SYRIA — Syria is open to letting Russia keep its air and naval bases along the Mediterranean coast as long as any agreement with the Kremlin serves the country’s interests, Syrian Defense Minister Murhaf Abu Qasra said in an interview this week, underscoring the pragmatic approach taken by his government as it charts new alliances and reassesses old ones forged under the previous regime.

Russia’s attitude toward the new Syrian government has “improved significantly” since the fall of President Bashar al-Assad in December, and Damascus is weighing Moscow’s demands, Abu Qasra said, signaling a dramatic shift among the former militants who make up the government.

Until recently, rebel fighters like Abu Qasra, a key leader in Syria’s insurgency, were under constant bombardment by Russian warplanes. But “in politics, there are no permanent enemies,” he said of Moscow, once Assad’s most powerful ally. Asked if Russia would be allowed to maintain its naval port at Tartus and the Hmeimim air base in Latakia, Abu Qasra said: “If we get benefits for Syria out of this, yes.”

In a wide-ranging interview Sunday in Damascus, Abu Qasra, 40, discussed Syria’s moves to build new military and political partnerships, its efforts to negotiate with U.S.-backed Kurdish forces, and its ambitious plans to bring the country’s plethora of armed factions, which mushroomed during the civil war, under the control of a single, unified

SEE SYRIA ON A11

Life in the ‘uninhabitable’ Gaza Strip



ABDEL KAREEM HANA/AP

A tent camp for displaced Palestinians is set up Thursday in Jabalya in the northern Gaza Strip. In pushing for a U.S. takeover of Gaza, the White House this week called it “an uninhabitable place.” Unexploded bombs are hindering reconstruction in the enclave, where the war damaged or destroyed an estimated 60 percent of buildings. **Story, A10**

On X, Musk holds court for fans and supplicants

BY WILL OREMUS

Elon Musk posted a poll question to his X followers on Tuesday afternoon. “Would you like DOGE to audit the IRS?” Within 24 hours, nearly 2 million X users had voted: 51 percent chose “yes,” and 41 percent selected “F yes” with a raised-hands emoji. Just 8 percent said “no.”

In Washington, Musk’s incursion into the federal government has triggered alarm, protests and lawsuits. Polls show a majority of Americans disapprove of the billionaire’s role in President Donald

Trump’s administration.

But on X, the social media platform Musk owns and inhabits, the conservative political and tech influencers who form his digital circle are hailing his march through federal institutions as a heroic disruption of bureaucracy — and Musk is soaking up their adulation while taking suggestions on his next targets.

With Musk’s U.S. DOGE (Department of Government Efficiency)

SEE MUSK ON A14

Federal personnel data: DOGE access alarms security officials. **A5**

DOGE uses AI to probe sensitive federal data

BY HANNAH NATANSON, GERRIT DE VYNCK, ELIZABETH DWOSKIN AND DANIELLE DOUGLAS-GABRIEL

Representatives from Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service have fed sensitive data from across the Education Department into artificial intelligence software to probe the agency’s programs and spending, according to two people with knowledge of the DOGE team’s actions.

The AI probe includes data with personally identifiable information for people who manage

grants, as well as sensitive internal financial data, the two people said. They described DOGE activities at the Education Department on the condition of anonymity due to fear of retaliation.

The DOGE team is using AI software accessed through Microsoft’s cloud computing service Azure to pore over every dollar of money the department disburses, from contracts to grants to work trip expenses, one of the people

SEE DOGE ON A15

Precautions: A guide to locking down digital communications. **A20**

Trump buyout offer is paused

JUDGE ORDERS HALT AMID LITIGATION

Deadline for federal staff is extended to Monday

This article is by Olivia George, Steve Thompson, Emily Davies, Rachel Siegel and Lisa Rein

A judge in Massachusetts temporarily paused the Trump administration’s buyout program for federal workers Thursday afternoon, two days after unions representing more than 800,000 federal workers filed a lawsuit to delay the program’s deadline.

U.S. District Judge George A. O’Toole Jr. said the administration could not take further action on the program until a hearing Monday afternoon, when both sides can present more arguments on the case. To comply with the order, the Office of Personnel Management extended the deadline for federal employees to Monday, Feb. 10, at 11:59 p.m. Eastern time, according to a post from the agency on X.

The change further plunged workers into limbo, as the administration pushes to drastically

SEE BUYOUTS ON A13

What happened on Thursday

The Senate confirmed Russell Vought as the director of the White House budget office.

President Donald Trump signed an order imposing sanctions on the International Criminal Court.

The Justice Department sued Illinois and Chicago over protections for undocumented immigrants. **A4**

Amid the chaos, Trump voters like what they see

Washington is reeling, but these supporters in Pennsylvania say that’s exactly what they wanted

BY NATALIE ALLISON

PLAINS, PA. — Behind the counter of the pink-tiled D’s Diner, Tammy Malloy chatted in between serving a late morning wave of tables. The 67-year-old said she had come to work beaming the day after the November election, in which she had voted for Donald Trump.

And now, weeks into Trump’s second presidency, Malloy was still thrilled with what she was seeing happen in Washington. She was particularly pleased with Trump choosing Pete Hegseth, a former weekend Fox News host and Army veteran who was dogged by allegations of sexual misconduct and alcohol abuse, to lead the Defense Department. Why?

“To get rid of the DEI,” Malloy said, using the acronym for diversity, equity and inclusion efforts, a favorite conservative punching bag. “There’s two genders. I don’t care if you identify as a monkey, you’re still either a male or female. The last four years shoved it down our throats.”

But she thought Trump was being too generous in offering resignation deals for federal employees who don’t want to return to work in the office. It’s the only thing so far she’s disliked that Trump has done — a list that includes freezing various federal grant programs in an effort to weed out diversity initiatives and pardoning violent offenders who participated in the attack on the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021.

“I can’t work from home,” Malloy said, standing by the diner’s swinging kitchen door, holding a half-glass of milk, with a black apron tied around her torso.

Despite the chaos and confusion some of Trump’s early actions have caused in Washington, there

SEE VOTERS ON A6

Climate efforts: “Lifesaving” work is on hold as USAID is targeted. **A9**

Layoffs: Contractors and small businesses are shedding jobs. **A15**

TPS: After Venezuela, protected migrants fear they’re next. **A20**



PETE KIEHART FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A bipartisan tradition on the Hill

Naval Academy midshipmen sing at the Capitol, where President Donald Trump spoke about religion — and politics — at Thursday’s National Prayer Breakfast.

Lawsuits signal the start of pushback by liberals

President’s opponents are looking to the courts and finding early success

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

As President Donald Trump opens his presidency with a barrage of actions that critics say defy or ignore existing laws, his opponents, after a brief period of shocked paralysis, have ramped up dozens of lawsuits that now form the leading edge of the liberal pushback against his second-term agenda.

This time, the resistance is unfolding in the courts rather than the streets.

FBI agents are suing over Trump’s plans to target agents who investigated the Jan. 6, 2021, U.S. Capitol rioters. Unions have asked a judge to block Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service from accessing Americans’ personal information. A coalition of educators has challenged the president’s move to kill diversity programs.

And it’s working, at least in

some cases: Courts have blocked Trump’s push to end birthright citizenship and to impose a freeze on federal grants. On Tuesday, U.S. District Judge Royce C. Lamberth halted an administration plan to transfer three transgender women to a men’s prison, part of Trump’s attack on what he calls the “woke” transgender movement.

“There is a very sophisticated litigation strategy to go after these unlawful actions,” Sen. Tim Kaine (D-Virginia) said in an interview, adding that Trump is essentially challenging the courts to stop him. “That is what is happening. ‘We will do whatever we want regardless of a legal rationale, and then folks can sue us.’ I think the Trump administration believes it will generally prevail in the court system the country now has. He may be wrong about that.”

Kaine acknowledged that some federal courts, including a U.S. Supreme Court reshaped by Trump in his first term, may favor the president on some issues. “We can’t go into it feeling like, ‘I know we are going to win all these cases,’” the senator said. “But we

SEE LAWSUITS ON A7

IN THE NEWS

Creating confusion Trump officials’ moves to shutter or remake federal offices focused on the environment are leading to turmoil. **A2**

Maryland health secretary to resign Laura Herrera Scott, who has led the state’s embattled health department for two years, is leaving at the end of the month. **B1**

THE NATION Recent bird flu infections suggest cows may be more susceptible than experts thought. **A2** **Some in** the nation’s scientific community are whispering existential doubts. **A3**

THE WORLD Asylum seekers deported to Colombia from the United States wonder what’s next. **A8** **The largest iceberg** in the world is moving toward an island north of Antarctica. **A11**

THE ECONOMY Efforts to dismantle USAID have put U.S. businesses that sell goods and services to the agency, including farms, in limbo. **A12** **Google’s parent** will no longer use hiring goals to boost workplace diversity in the wake of executive orders. **A15**

THE REGION Flights into Reagan National Airport are being reduced indefinitely after the collision between a jet and an Army helicopter. **B1** **A long-awaited** new D.C. hospital, Cedar Hill Regional Medical Center GW Health, will open April 15. **B1**

OBITUARIES Henry L. Marsh III, a civil rights lawyer and Virginia state senator who in 1977 became the first Black mayor of Richmond, was 91. **B1**

WEEKEND Yasmin Williams is a visionary guitarist who writes songs at home and on mountaintops.

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